

Q How can I prepare for my baby's injections and comfort him after?

Like most new parents, you may feel ill at ease about taking your baby for his immunizations but rest assured it is a very quick and efficient procedure.

Your young baby will be unaware that he is being immunized, but he may pick up on your tension if you feel stressed. While it's a natural instinct to be concerned, try to stay as relaxed as possible and remember that being immunized is in your baby's best interests.

Try not to plan anything else for that day, before or after the immunizations, so that you don't feel rushed and have proper time to focus on your baby's needs afterward.

What happens

When you take your baby to the doctor's office for his immunization, the nurse may suggest that you sit him on your lap while the injection is given. He will be soothed by your presence, touch, and voice, so talk to him gently, and give him a reassuring hug as he is immunized. You may also want to breast-feed your baby while he is being injected, which will be comforting

for him and provide a distraction from the shot. Some babies may not even cry or have a reaction if they are nursing when they receive their vaccinations. Your baby will most likely receive his vaccinations at his regular well-visit appointments, unless you're told to make a separate appointment.

Giving pain relief

If your baby develops a fever and seems uncomfortable, you can give the recommended dose of infant acetaminophen or ibuprofen, and continue with his regular feedings to keep him well hydrated.

It's very important that you do not give a dose of pain relief before an immunization, in anticipation of your baby developing a fever, because doing this could compromise the effectiveness of the vaccine.

After care Following his immunizations, give your baby infant pain relief to help lower any fever and ease discomfort.



Did you know...

Vaccination programs have been extremely effective around the world. For example, in 1914 in England and Wales there were approximately 60,000 cases of diphtheria, which caused 5,800 deaths. Following the introduction of the vaccine in 1942, there were 41,404 known cases and 1,827 deaths from the disease. By 1946, the diphtheria death rate had fallen to just 472.

In Japan in 1974, around 70 percent of Japanese children were being vaccinated against whooping cough and there were only 393 cases in all of Japan. When immunizations rates began to drop, only 10 percent of children were being vaccinated. The result was that more than 13,000 people developed whooping cough in 1979, of which 41 died. When children began to be routinely vaccinated again, the cases of whooping cough fell again.

Q Will there be any side effects from the immunizations?

It's natural to worry about possible side effects from vaccinations, but these tend to be mild and short-lived if they occur at all. There may be some local swelling and redness, and possibly a small lump at the injection site (usually the top of the thigh), all of which are harmless and disappear within a couple of days.

Occasionally babies develop a fever after an injection, in which case infant acetaminophen can be given. It's very rare for babies to have an allergic reaction to a vaccination. If it does happen, it is treatable.

Premature babies have immunizations at the same age as other babies—their immunity from their mother lasts the same two months.

Q My baby has eczema. Can he still have his immunizations?

Having an allergy, such as eczema, asthma, or any type of food intolerance, does not prevent your baby from being immunized. The only reasons for not immunizing your baby on a particular day would be if he had a fever, in which case the appointment would be rescheduled. If you are concerned that your child is not well enough on that day, seek advice from the doctor. If your child had a previous bad reaction to an immunization, (although this is rare) again, seek advice from the pediatrician.

Q Is it true that I can't take my baby swimming until he has had his shots?

It is a common myth that babies can't go swimming before they have their injections. You can take your baby swimming at any time before or after he has been immunized.